



performance, people who are young and who we can groom for longer,” he added.

A workaround for this is to have an IPC-backed event in India.

“We want to bring an IPC-approved Grand Prix to India around March or April next year. This is a calendar classification event and will be the first time India hosts it. Around October or November, we also want to host the Para Athletics World Championships. When we are the host country, we get more slots. If we get that approved, then this will be an event we will have every year.”

Athletes across the board explain that they need to move abroad to get internationally classified, but Rana clarifies that athletes can very well get qualified in their own countries, provided the classifier isn’t of the same nationality.

Rana, a UK-certified Musculoskeletal Physiotherapist, has spent time at the IPC, training as a classifier in swimming, and understands the grey area para sports classification comes with.

Ruthless rules: “I would head to various competitions, and there would be a letter preceding my arrival. It’s agonising to go through this mentally and emotionally, as this brings a lot of uncertainty”: Deepa Malik. GETTY IMAGES

“A lot of times, athletes aren’t very aware of their classification. Amputees give us visual evidence of the body part that is missing, but with cerebral palsy or spinal cord injuries or visual impairments, the grey area becomes a bit larger. It’s not about tools or tests being inadequate; it depends on assessing the disability on a case-by-case basis. The same condition can present different consequences for different people.

“It’s also important to remember that the sport itself is a massive leveller. Swimming’s class system is point-based. The entire body is divided into points, and your class depends on how many points are deducted from 290. How those points get cut might be different for

Know your class



If an athlete’s physical impairment is part of these 10 eligibility criteria parameters, he or she can be a part of the Paralympic movement:

- ✪ **Impaired Muscle Power** – Reduced or no ability to voluntarily contract muscles in order to move or to generate force.
- ✪ **Impaired Passive Range of Movement** – Restricted or a lack of passive movement in one or more joints.
- ✪ **Limb Deficiency** – Total or partial absence of bones or joints as a consequence of trauma (for example traumatic amputation), illness (for example amputation due to bone cancer) or congenital limb deficiency (for example dysmelia).
- ✪ **Leg Length Difference** – Difference in the length of legs as a result of a disturbance of limb growth, or as a result of trauma.
- ✪ **Short Stature** – Reduced length in the bones of the upper limbs, lower limbs and/or trunk.
- ✪ **Hypertonia** – Increase in muscle tension and a reduced ability of a muscle to stretch caused by damage to the central nervous system.
- ✪ **Ataxia** – Uncoordinated movements caused by damage to the central nervous system.
- ✪ **Athetosis** – Continual slow involuntary movements.
- ✪ **Vision Impairment** – Reduced, or no vision caused by damage to the eye structure, optical nerves or optical pathways, or visual cortex of the brain.
- ✪ **Intellectual Impairment** – Restriction in intellectual functioning and adaptive behaviour which affects conceptual, social and practical adaptive skills required for everyday life. This impairment must be present before the age of 18.

*Source: paralympic.org/athletics/classification

two athletes, but the athletes in a class are put at a similar disadvantage by the water,” he added. The need to be as foolproof as possible with classifications is also key in preventing malpractice, and the IPC’s new classification code seeks to address just that.

“Next year, a new edition of the classification code has been approved by the International Paralympic Committee’s Annual General Body. Another criterion will be introduced.

“First, we went with meeting the minimum impairment criterion, but now athletes need to provide evidence for the underlying health condition that’s causing the disability as well. It will help guard against malpractice in a better way,” Rana said.